

RESEARCH PROPOSAL

Brand Overview

Boston University's School of Hospitality Administration (BU SHA) is a Boston-based academic institution offering undergraduate and graduate degrees in hospitality and service management. The school covers traditional sectors such as hotels, restaurants, and tourism, as well as emerging applications in healthcare, sports, entertainment, and retail. SHA combines industry-focused courses, field experiences, and international opportunities with a broad liberal arts education.

Objective

The goal of this research is to explore how SHA students, faculty, and staff perceive the school's culture, community, and opportunities for collaboration. It will examine how experiences, relationships, and shared spaces influence inclusion and engagement, and identify opportunities to strengthen participation, recognition, and pride in SHA.

1) Assess the current perception of the community within all SHA affiliated groups.

- Student-Specific:
 - Which interactions contribute most to students feeling included or excluded within SHA, and how do aspects such as peer support, faculty engagement, or event structure influence these experiences?
 - How do students interpret and engage with SHA's traditions, events, and shared spaces in ways that encourage connection or personal meaning?
 - To what extent do academic or social goals align with SHA's broader culture?
- Faculty/Staff Specific:
 - In what context do faculty and staff feel they have the most impact on students' experiences?
 - How do communication methods, routines, or department practices shape staff and faculty's perception of community?
 - What factors or experiences make SHA faculty and staff feel included and valued within the broader school community?

2) Identify both barriers and motivators in student participation (SHA events).

- What drives students to take part in events or initiatives (personal growth, social connections, skill development, career preparation, etc.)?
- How do students perceive the benefits of participation, both tangible (skills, networking) and abstract (belonging, recognition)? Does this perception affect their engagement?
- What factors prevent students from participating consistently, even in activities that they consider valuable?
- How do certain social dynamics, peer influence, or community affect the likelihood of joining or returning to activities?
- Describe any challenges, like schedule conflicts or competing priorities that make it difficult to participate in activities.

3) Analyze social media engagement patterns.

- Student-Specific:
 - In what ways do students interact with SHA's social media accounts, including liking, viewing, sharing, or commenting?
 - Which types of content, topics, or formats capture attention and encourage engagement?

- How do students use social media to stay informed about events, programs, or opportunities at SHA?
- Are there types of content that students notice but engage with less frequently, and what factors might explain this?
- Faculty/Staff-Specific:
 - Does SHA's social media seem to communicate the school's culture, values, and opportunities to staff and students?
 - How could staff or faculty contributions be represented online to improve visibility and support understanding?

Target Audience

BU SHA's undergraduate and graduate students, faculty and staff

Demographic:

- Primary Audience:
 - Ages 18-27 (students)
- Secondary Audience:
 - 30-60 (faculty and staff)
- Based in Boston, MA
- Enrolled or employed at BU SHA

Psychographic:

- People-first and driven
- Motivated by meaningful relationships, real-world experiences, and personal growth
- See hospitality as more than service (creating connections)
- Value authenticity, collaboration, and community

Behavior:

- Participate in classes, group projects, and internships but may not always attend school events.
- Active on social media (especially Instagram, TikTok, and LinkedIn).
- Engage in online spaces to share achievements or network professionally.
- Look for authenticity in how their school communicates and celebrates its people.

Research Plan

Primary Research

- **IDIs with SHA students** (undergrad & graduate students)
 - Platform: In-person/Zoom
 - Number of Participants: 5-10
 - Sourcing methods: Online recruitment (through social media/LinkedIn), word of mouth (asking friends and acquaintances), QR codes in BU buildings
 - Length: 30-45 mins
 - Objective: Understand how SHA students define "community," how connected they feel to peers/faculty, and what authentic "Experience Innovation" looks like to them.
 - Discussion topics:
 - What makes SHA feel like a community?
 - When do you feel most connected or disconnected from your peers, professors or even the school?
 - Does SHA's close-knit environment affect your experience positively or negatively? Elaborate on how it does.

- What does “Experience Innovation” mean in their daily life at SHA?
 - Can you think of an example like a class or a project that felt innovative and hands-on?
 - How does this idea of “experience” show up in areas outside of academics (like networking, student organizations or internships)?
 - When you talk about SHA to your friends outside of the program, what would you say stands out to you the most when you describe your experiences?
- What motivates you to take part in SHA’s events, clubs, and programs?
 - Which events feel most rewarding to you and why? (personal growth, connections, relationships, career development)
 - What challenges do you face staying involved on campus?
 - Do your peers/friends influence your decision to go to an event or staying active in a student organization?
 - What do you think would make participation easier ?
- How do you use SHA’s social media and platforms to stay updated?
 - What kind of posts catch your attention the most? E.g., student spotlights, career fairs, events, student takeovers etc.
 - Are there times where you find yourself scrolling past content posted by SHA? If so, why?
 - Do you share or repost content about SHA? If you do, how often and what motivates you to do so?
 - How can SHA’s online presence feel like an extension of the real community experience?
- If you could improve one thing about SHA’s community, what would it be?
 - What would make you feel more prideful about representing SHA?
 - How do you think SHA could better highlight the experiences and people that make it unique?
 - If there was one thing you would want to change about SHA, what it would be and why? And what is the one thing you hope never changes about SHA and why?
- **IDI’s (with faculty/staff)**
 - Platform: In-person or over Zoom
 - Number of Participants: 3-4
 - Sourcing methods: Research then personally reach out via email, reach out to client for potential contacts
 - Length: 30–45 minutes
 - Objective: Learn faculty perspectives on community culture and how they integrate “Experience Innovation” into teaching or events.
 - Discussion Topics:
 - What defines SHA’s sense of community from your perspective?
 - How would you describe the relationship between students, staff and faculty here?
 - How do specific experiences, events, or interactions contribute to your sense of community at SHA?
 - How would you say SHA’s smaller class sizes or close-knit reputation affects the culture here?
 - What initiatives help students feel connected to SHA?
 - Are there any specific student organizations, mentorship programs or events that you believe help establish connections?

- How do you see freshmen integrating into the SHA community?
 - What challenges have you faced with having undergraduate/graduate students stay engaged?
- How do you think “Experience Innovation” shows up in the student experience?
 - How do you personally incorporate experiential or hands-on learning into your teaching?
 - Are there any projects or programs that really capture the spirit of innovation?
 - What skills or mindsets do you think students gain through the experiential model of learning?
- What could strengthen connection among students, faculty, and staff?
- Do you see more room for collaboration and communication within the community? If so, where?
- How might SHA better celebrate student and faculty achievements?
- Are there any digital or physical tools/platforms that help improve this sense of belonging?
- If there was one thing you would want to change about SHA, what it would be and why? And what is the one thing you hope never changes about SHA and why?
- **Online Survey (Students)**
 - Platform: Qualtrics
 - Respondents: 100–150 students
 - Sourcing methods: Online (via social media/Linkedin), incentivize participation (SONA credits)
 - Length: 5-8 minutes
 - Objective: Quantify themes around engagement and recognition of SHA’s “Experience Innovation” identity.
 - Question Topics: (a bit more general than focus groups)
 - Demographic:
 - Age
 - Graduation year
 - Major/minor
 - Event participation and reasons for attending/not attending
 - Feelings of belonging and connection within SHA
 - Awareness and perception of “Experience Innovation”
 - Preferred communication platforms
 - Motivators for participating in community activities
- **Online Survey (Faculty)**
 - Platform: Qualtrics
 - Respondents: 20-30 (mix of full- and part-time faculty)
 - Sourcing methods: Online distribution via faculty email lists (client assistance needed)
 - Length: 5-8 minutes
 - Objective: Complement insights from faculty interviews by gathering broader perspectives on community culture and “Experience Innovation.”
 - Question Topics:
 - Demographic:
 - Role at SHA
 - Perceptions of SHA’s sense of community
 - Involvement in or awareness of student-focused initiatives
 - Role of “Experience Innovation” in teaching and curriculum
 - Communication and collaboration between students, faculty, and staff
 - Suggestions to improve connection and recognition within SHA

Secondary Research

- Social Media Audit

- Sources: Instagram, TikTok, LinkedIn, Youtube, Facebook
- Objective: Evaluate how effectively SHA's social media presence reflects its Experience Innovation positioning and community-driven identity, and look for untapped opportunities for engagement.
 - Focus Areas:
 - Audience interaction and identity mapping
 - Review likes, comments, and tagged content to identify engagement patterns. For example, users utilizing SHA hashtags or talking about projects, internships, classes and more.
 - Categorize interactions not by assumptions but through observable behavior. E.g., key words like "my professor" or "my classes at SHA" or even tagging other students from SHA could indicate some form of internal community. Users who comment without any mentions of SHA could represent external audiences such as parents, friends or other strangers.
 - Content performance and opportunity analysis:
 - Assess the kind of content (student events, faculty features, event recaps etc) that performs well not only by likes/comments but by qualitative engagement.
 - Identify the areas that don't have as much engagement (e.g. static posts) and formulate ideas for tactics that could increase interest and drive higher connections such as student takeovers and behind the scenes content.
 - Explore the gaps between students who make SHA-related content and SHA's main account. SHA could amplify these stories by resharing them.
 - Brand personality and aligning perception
 - Conduct an analysis on the tone of content. Is SHA's visual language and tone consistent with "authentic, spirited, and collaborative"?
 - Compare the brand's tone and audience sentiment by analyzing the language used in comments, content and even hashtags.
 - Benchmark SHA's content's voice and aesthetics against its competitors to see if SHA stands out as innovative, approachable, and community-driven.
 - Sourcing Methods:
 - Use manual tracking through TikTok and Instagram's search filters and by using certain keywords.
 - Track engagement metrics through Instagram Insights and third-party tools.
 - Supplement data with student surveys and quotes from focus groups to cross-validate audience perception with digital tone.

- Competitive Analysis

- Sources: Meltwater, competitor websites/social media, Reddit
- Objective: Compare SHA's communication style and student engagement strategies with other BU schools and select hospitality programs.
 - Focus Areas:
 - Benchmark against internal BU colleges (e.g., Questrom, COM, Wheelock) and other hospitality schools (e.g., NYU SPS, Cornell Nolan).
 - Analyze tone, visual identity, messaging, and community-building tactics across websites and social media.
 - Identify key differentiators and potential inspiration points for how SHA can highlight "Experience Innovation" authentically.
 - Sourcing Methods:
 - Review each competitor's Instagram, LinkedIn, and website.

- Observe event promotion methods, content frequency, and brand tone.
- Note standout campaigns or digital engagement initiatives.
- **Trend Study**
 - Sources: Mintel, Statista, MRI Simmons
 - Objective: Understand broader trends around Gen Z engagement, community-building, and campus identity on social media.
 - Focus Areas:
 - Identify emerging content formats (e.g., student takeovers, mini-docs, candid storytelling) that drive emotional engagement.
 - Look into social media and cultural trends that align with SHA's values of collaboration, innovation, and inclusivity.
 - Sourcing Methods:
 - Research through articles, case studies, and reports
 - Review secondary databases and online publications

Results

Findings will be presented in a **Google Slides Research Report**, including:

- Key Insights and direct quotes from interviews/focus groups
- Data visualizations (charts/graphs) summarizing survey findings
- Analysis of engagement motivators/barriers
- Social media and competitor content analysis
- Strategic recommendations to enhance SHA's internal community communications

Timeline

Key Milestone	Start Date	End Date
Draft + Revise research questions (survey + interviews)	10/16/2025	10/20/2025
Recruit participants (students/faculty/staff)	10/21/2025	10/24/2025
Conduct secondary research (social media audit, competitive analysis, trend study)	10/21/2025	10/27/2025
Conduct focus groups (students)	10/28/2025	10/31/2025
Conduct IDI's (faculty/staff)	11/01/2025	11/04/2025
Design and distribute online surveys (Qualtrics)	10/30/2025	11/02/2025
Collect and monitor survey responses	11/02/2025	11/04/2025
Analyze qualitative and quantitative data	11/05/2025	11/08/2025
Draft/Finalize report	11/09/2025	11/14/2025

Additional Considerations

- Access to social media accounts analytics
 - Client has indicated they are willing to provide relevant metrics